

Wilmers De fide divina

De fide divina libri quatuor — Applicationes: nn. 254–256 (*On Divine Faith, Four Books — Applications: nn. 254–256*)

by Wilhelm Wilmers, S.J. (1817–1899); opus postumum, edited by Augustinus Lehmkuhl, S.J.; Ratisbon: Friedrich Pustet, 1902 (imprimatur Ratisbon, 9 April 1902)

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- *Selection: Articulus IV ("Doctrinæ hoc capite expositæ nonnullæ applicationes"), nn. 254–256*

Note on this selection: the third Wilmers entry in this repository (with the 1891 Handbook and the 1897 De Christi Ecclesia), and doctrinally the sharpest. These sections are the applications of his Propositio 53 — a proposition legitimately deduced from a revealed universal by means of a naturally certain premise can be believed by divine faith (the Suárez–Lugo position, against the ecclesiastical-faith school). Application II is the pope-case, stated as a thesis with the reigning pope named: "It can be believed by divine faith that this man, for example Leo XIII, is the successor of Peter and the true head of the Church" — with John of St. Thomas quoted on the seventeenth-century celebrity of the question (cf. the 1640 John of St. Thomas entry). Three features deserve notice. (1) The acceptance stands inside the revealed major itself: the perpetual successor "will be he who, elected in the manner the Church judges fitting, is accepted, or acknowledged, by the universal Church" — and the thesis expressly concerns him "who is commonly reputed canonically elected, and especially who has been accepted by the whole Church as true Pope." (2) The epistemology of the minor premise is the acceptance-criterion: no one need scrutinize the election's particulars, for "the universal acknowledgment following the election plainly suffices" for moral certainty of both the mode and the person — crowned by the reductio: were that not sufficient, "it would have to be admitted

that God had not provided a sufficient means by which the true head may be known, without which nevertheless the Church cannot exist; nay, that the Church had perhaps for whole centuries lacked her true head, and had not known it, and had conformed her faith to the judgments and definitions of a man to whom infallibility had not been promised by Christ” — Cano’s magistrates-reductio (1563 entry) and Hervé’s infallible-sign argument (1952 entry) fused into one sentence. (3) All of this holds “supposita interim sola certitudine morali,” before and apart from any definition of the Church — the same pre-definition certitude Castro Palao affirmed in 1631. Note also n. 254’s parallel application to the Church herself (this individual Church subject to the Roman Pontiff is the true Church — believable fide divina by the same syllogistic route), and n. 256’s tidy answer to the schism-not-heresy objection. Under this repository’s two-verdict distinction, Wilmers affirms both the fact and the strong note: the conclusion is implicitly revealed and believable by divine faith.

Articulus IV — Doctrinæ hoc capite expositæ nonnullæ applicationes (nn. 254–256)

[254] It must be shown how certain particular facts or individual things of great importance in revelation, though comprehended under general [divine] faith, can be believed with divine faith, assuming in the meantime only moral certainty concerning their revelation. How these same things can be believed given a definition by the Church will be inquired into later.

I. *It can be believed with divine faith that this individual Church, which is subject to the Roman Pontiff as universal and supreme pastor, is the true Church of Christ.*

a. That the true Church must be believed, and that the Church which is proposed for belief is one and individual Church, we have demonstrated elsewhere. *De Eccl.* Props. 81 and 82. Above (Prop. 44 cor. 4) we have also shown that the Church can be believed [with divine faith] even though it is visible, or rather that visibility does not prevent it from being believed with divine faith. What must be shown here is that this individual Church, whose head is the Roman Pontiff, can be believed with divine faith.

b. A fact can be believed with divine faith which is included in Christ’s revelation and is known with moral certainty. Now indeed, that the Church which is subject to the Roman Pontiff as universal and supreme pastor is the true Church—this is contained in Christ’s revelation and is known with moral certainty. Therefore it can be believed with divine faith.

For indeed, the true Church is that which is one, holy, catholic, and apostolic; this is revealed truth. But the Church which is subject to the Roman Pontiff is one, holy, catholic, and apostolic; this is established with moral certainty from what has been demonstrated in the treatise *On the Church*. Therefore, the Church which is subject to the Roman Pontiff is the true Church. This conclusion, which is inferred from one revealed premise and another known by natural light, can be affirmed and therefore believed on account of God’s testimony alone.

[255] II. *It can be believed by divine faith that this man, for example Leo XIII, is the successor of Peter and the true head of the Church.*

“This question,” so says Johannes a Sancto Thoma, “has become very celebrated in these times and has been debated with various arguments, for concerning it little is found among the ancients in the terms in which it is now disputed.” *On Faith* disp. 8, art. 2,

n. 1.

The matter concerns him who is commonly considered to have been canonically elected, and especially one who has been accepted by the entire Church as the true Pope.

a. The stated opinion is legitimately inferred from one revealed premise and another certain through natural knowledge; it is therefore itself also implicitly revealed and can be believed on account of revelation.

There will be in the Church a perpetual successor of Peter and a true head of the Church (*De Ecclesia* Prop. 37). And he will be the one who, having been elected by the Church in the manner that seems fitting to her, is accepted or acknowledged by the universal Church. But Leo XIII is he who has been elected by the Church in the manner that seems appropriate to her, and acknowledged by the universal Church. Therefore, Leo XIII is the successor of Peter and the true head of the Church. The conclusion is inferred from one premise that is revealed and another that is certain by natural reason, and therefore it can be believed with divine faith.

That there will perpetually be someone as Peter's successor in the Church, and therefore that a successor must be constituted, has been revealed; but how he who would succeed Peter in the Roman chair, which he had established as the principal chair, should be constituted or elected, has not been revealed, and therefore has been committed to the judgment of the Church. Cf. *De Ecclesia* n. 117 and Prop. 39.

Furthermore, in order for us to be certain that this person or that person has been legitimately elected, it is not necessary for us ourselves to examine individually each thing that was done, whether it concerns the person elected or the manner of election. Universal recognition following the election plainly suffices to generate moral certainty both concerning the legitimate manner of election and concerning the qualities of the elected person that are absolutely required for a valid election. For if this universal recognition and conviction were not sufficient, it would have to be admitted that God had not provided a sufficient means by which the true head could be known—without whom, however, the Church cannot exist. Indeed, it would have to be admitted that the Church had perhaps lacked a true head for entire centuries and had been ignorant of this fact, and had conformed its faith to the judgments and definitions of a man to whom infallibility had not been promised by Christ. (For what should be thought concerning a Pope elected simoniacally, see *De Eccl.* n. 147 p. 257).

b. The opinion is confirmed from the 39 articles concerning which Martin V in the Council of Constance by the Bull "Inter cunctas" decreed that those who were suspected of the errors of Wyclif and Hus should be interrogated. Of these articles, here is the 24th: "Whether he believes that the Pope canonically elected, whoever he may be for the time being, his proper name being expressly stated, is the successor of blessed Peter having supreme authority in the Church of God." In the immediately preceding article (23), it is established that the suspect is to be interrogated: "Whether he believes that blessed Peter was the vicar of Christ, having the power of binding and loosing upon earth"; and in the immediately following article (25): "Whether he believes that the jurisdictional authority of the Pope, archbishop, and bishop in loosing and binding is greater than the authority of a simple priest, even if he has the care of souls." In these two articles the word *believing* undoubtedly signifies divine faith (Cf. *De Ecclesia* Prop. 56); therefore, since the Bull speaks in the same manner in those three articles, it must be supposed that even in the intermediate article it employs the word *believing* in the same sense. *Denzinger* n. 567—569.

[256] This does not contradict the fact that those who withdraw from obedience to the Supreme Pontiff are called schismatics, not heretics. For schism does not necessarily involve heresy, since even one who acknowledges the supreme jurisdiction of this Pope can pertinaciously refuse obedience, and therefore does not deny the faith. Moreover, in the forum of the Church, those are customarily called heretics not who deny some article however it may be revealed, but only those who deny an article proposed by the Church as to be believed.

The opinion set forth above is held, among others, by: *Francisco Suárez* (who is sometimes wrongly cited in favor of the opposing opinion) *On Faith*, disputation 10, section 5; *John de Lugo*, disputation 1, section 13, number 325; *John of St. Thomas*, *On Faith*, disputation 6, article 2.

Those who depart from the far more common opinion are led principally by this reasoning: that sufficient certainty cannot be established concerning a legitimate election and the requisite conditions of the elected person. Thus *Báñez* in 2. 2. q. 1. a. 10, dub. 2, arg. 2 ad 2. respond. 4, where he finally concludes: “Nevertheless, it would be extremely rash and scandalous if, after the Church has accepted someone as Supreme Pontiff, anyone should deny that he is the true Supreme Pontiff, unless he could demonstrate that he was not baptized, etc.” But it should be noted that what cannot be proven a priori and immediately can often be proven mediately and from the outcome. From the universal acceptance of someone as Pontiff, we conclude that he is the true Pontiff. From the fact that he is the true Pontiff, we conclude that he does not lack the absolutely necessary conditions; and this is justified because it must always be presupposed that God’s providence does not fail the Church in necessary matters.